

games accounts for anything more than 10 per cent of your reason for buying a PC. ATI's Radeon HD 4670 GPU is a good contender for an entry-level gaming solution, as is NVIDIA's GeForce 9600 GT – both of these will play most games at decent resolutions (1280 x 1024 and 1440 x 900) with reasonable detail. Obviously, for games like *Crysis*, *Crysis Warhead* and *Clear Sky* you will need to

turn the settings down all the way. Some of these cards will be available for less than Rs. 6,000 and typically most of the cards will feature 512 MB of RAM – ensure this is DDR3 memory. DDR2 versions can offer as much as 1 GB of VRAM, but being slower this isn't of much good.

For Rs. 9,000 ATI's Radeon HD 4850 is a good card and will allow you to play all games, but you will need to smart with the visual settings. You might also want to look at the Radeon HD 5770, which is cheaper since it's built on a smaller fab, but an excellent performer. For Rs. 14,000 or so, NVIDIA's GTX 260 and ATI's HD 4870 1 GB are hard to beat. Choose either, they're pretty much even.

If you're slightly more hardcore and looking to spend around Rs. 22,000 or so, I have two recommendations: either buy a GTX 285 graphics card for around Rs. 22,000, or save up till you have Rs. 26,000 and blow it on an ATI Radeon HD 5870 – which is a shiny new DX 11 part that outperforms the GTX 285 by a decent margin. In fact the Radeon HD 5870 is a sweet buy and one that is also future (read DX 11) proof. NVIDIA's GTX 295 is faster, but also costlier (at least Rs. 32,000) and I don't recommend it. If you're looking to spend more than Rs. 30,000 on a graphics card, chances are you won't mind spending another 20,000 bucks. If Rs. 50,000 be your budget for a pair of GPUs, pick up two ATI Radeon HD 5870s and buy a CrossFire-supporting motherboard, like Intel's X58.

I haven't mentioned brands, just GPUs. For NVIDIA, I suggest brands like ZOTAC, ASUS, EVGA, XFX and Galaxy. Availability of other brands may be sporadic or I'm not as convinced of their quality and service. For ATI, choose from Sapphire, XFX and PowerColor and ASUS – the three most trusted brands for me.



ZOTAC GeForce 9400 GT

